MINDFULNESS SESSION 8

- Thinking Mistakes
- Mindfulness of Current Thoughts

Thinking Mistakes

1. **ALL-OR-NOTHING, BLACK-AND-WHITE THINKING:** If you're not perfect, you're a total loser. If you don't get everything you want, it feels like you got nothing. If you're having a good day, the whole rest of your life is perfect and you don't need therapy anymore.

2. **CATASTROPHIZING (FORTUNETELLING ERROR):** You predict the future negatively without considering other, more likely outcomes. "I'm definitely going to fail my test," or "If I tell her that, she'll hate me forever."

3. **MIND READING:** You believe you know what other people are thinking even without asking. "He clearly doesn't think I will do a good job."

4. **OVERGENERALIZATION:** You make a sweeping, negative conclusion that goes far beyond the current situation. "Since I felt uncomfortable in my first day of class, I know that I won't be able to enjoy the rest of the year."

5. **MENTAL FILTER:** You develop selective hearing and vision and only hear and see the one negative thing and ignore the many positive things. "Because my supervisor gave me one low rating on my evaluation (that also had many higher ratings), it means I'm doing a terrible job."

6. **DISQUALIFYING THE POSITIVE:** You tell yourself that the positive experiences, actions, or qualities do not count. "I did well in that one basketball game because I just got lucky."

7. **EMOTIONAL REASONING:** You start thinking your emotions are fact. "I feel . . . ; therefore, it is. I feel like she hates me; therefore, she does." "I feel stupid; therefore I am stupid." "I dread school, so it's a bad idea to go."

8. **"SHOULD" STATEMENTS:** You "should" on yourself or someone else by having a fixed idea of how you or others should behave, and you overestimate how bad it will be if these expectations are not met. "It's terrible that I made a mistake; I should always do my best." "You shouldn't be so upset."

9. **LABELING:** Overgeneralization is taken a step further by the use of extreme language to describe things. "I spilled my milk. I am SUCH A LOSER!" "My therapist didn't call me right back; she is the most uncaring, heartless therapist ever!"

10. **PERSONALIZATION:** You see yourself as the cause for things you have absolutely no control over or the target of stuff that may have absolutely nothing to do with you. "My parents divorced because of me." "The receptionist was short with me because I did something wrong."

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Mindfulness of Current Thoughts

1. OBSERVE YOUR THOUGHTS.

- As waves, coming and going.
- Not suppressing thoughts.
- Not judging thoughts.
- Acknowledging their presence.
- Not keeping thoughts around.
- Not analyzing thoughts.
- Practicing willingness.
- Stepping back and observing thoughts as they run in and out of your mind.

2. ADOPT A CURIOUS MIND.

- Ask, “Where do my thoughts come from?” Watch and see.
- Notice that every thought that comes also goes out of your mind.
- Observe but do not evaluate your thoughts. Let go of judgments.

3. REMEMBER: YOU ARE NOT YOUR THOUGHTS.

- Do not necessarily act on thoughts.
- Remember times when you have had very different thoughts.
- Remind yourself that catastrophic thinking is “emotion mind.”
- Remember how you think when you are not feeling such intense suffering and pain.

4. DON'T BLOCK OR SURPRESS THOUGHTS.

- Ask, “What sensations are these thoughts trying to avoid?” Turn your mind to the sensation. Then come back to the thought. Repeat several times.
- Step back; allow your thoughts to come and go as you observe your breath.
- Play with your thoughts: Repeat them out loud over and over as fast as you can. Sing them. Imagine the thoughts as the words of a clown, as recordings getting all tangled up; as cute animals you can cuddle up to; as bright colors running through your mind; as only sounds.
- Try loving your thoughts.

Practicing Mindfulness of Thoughts

PRACTICE MINDFULNESS OF THOUGHTS BY OBSERVING THEM

- ❑ 1. Notice thoughts as they come into your mind. As a thought comes into your mind, say "a thought has entered my mind." Label the thought as a thought, saying, "The thought [describe thought] arose in my mind." Use a gentle voice tone.
- ❑ 2. As you notice thoughts in your mind, ask, "Where did the thought come from?" Then watch your mind to see if you can see where it came from.
- ❑ 3. Step back from your mind, as if you are on top of a mountain and your mind is just a boulder down below. Gaze at your mind, watching what thoughts come up when you are watching it. Come back into your mind before you stop.
- ❑ 4. Close your eyes and scan your body for the first physical sensation that you notice. Then scan your mind for the first thought you notice. Shuttle back and forth between scanning for physical sensations and scanning for thoughts. Another time, replace scanning your body for physical sensations to scanning yourself for any emotional feelings. Then shuttle back and forth between an emotional feeling and a thought.

PRACTICE MINDFULNESS OF THOUGHTS BY USING WORDS AND VOICE TONE

- ❑ 5. Verbalize thoughts or beliefs out loud, using a nonjudgmental voice tone, over and over and over:
  - ❑ As fast as you can until the thoughts make no sense.
  - ❑ Very, very slowly (one syllable or word per breath).
  - ❑ In a different voice from yours (high- or low-pitched, like a cartoon character or celebrity).
  - ❑ As a dialogue on a TV comedy show ("You'll never believe what thought went through my mind. I was thinking, 'I'm a jerk.' Can you believe that?").
  - ❑ As songs, sung wholeheartedly and dramatically, in a tune that fits the thoughts.

PRACTICE MINDFULNESS OF THOUGHTS WITH OPPOSITE ACTION

- ❑ 6. Relax your face and body while imagining accepting your thoughts as only thoughts—sensations of the brain.
- ❑ 7. Imagine things you would do if you stopped believing everything you think.
- ❑ 8. Rehearse in your mind the things that you would do if you did not view your thoughts as facts.
- ❑ 9. Practice loving your thoughts as they go through your mind.

(***continued on next page***)

PRACTICE MINDFULNESS OF THOUGHTS BY IMAGINING THAT YOUR MIND IS:

- ❑ 10. A conveyor belt, and that thoughts and feelings are coming down the belt. Put each thought or feeling in a box labeled with the type of thought that it is (e.g., worry thoughts, thoughts about my past, thoughts about my mother, planning what to do thoughts). Just keep observing and sorting thoughts into the labeled boxes.
- ❑ 11. A river, and that thoughts and feelings are boats going down the river. Imagine sitting on the grass, watching the boats go by. Try not to jump on the boat.
- ❑ 12. A railroad track, and that thoughts and feelings are train cars going by. Try not to jump on the train.
- ❑ 13. A leaf that has dropped off a tree into a beautiful creek flowing by you as you sit on the grass. Each time a thought or image comes into your mind, imagine that it is written or pictured on the leaf floating by. Let each leaf go by, watching as it goes out of sight.
- ❑ 14. The sky, and thoughts have wings and can fly through the sky. Watch as each flies out of sight.
- ❑ 15. The sky, and thoughts are clouds. Notice each thought-cloud as it drifts by, letting it drift out of your mind.
- ❑ 16. A white room with two doors. Through one door, thoughts come in; through the other, thoughts go out. Watch each thought with attention and curiosity until it leaves. Let go of judgments. Let go of analyzing thoughts and of figuring out if they fit the facts. As a thought comes into your mind, say, “A thought has entered my mind.”

Other: _____

Other: _____

Other: _____

Other: _____

Other: _____

Mindfulness of Current Thoughts

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Describe your efforts to observe your thoughts in the past week. Practice observing thoughts each day at least once. Don't focus just on thoughts that are painful, anxiety-provoking, or full of anger; also observe and be mindful of pleasant or neutral thoughts. For each thought, first practice saying, "The thought [describe thought] went through my mind." Then practice one or more strategies to observe and let go of thoughts.

Check off any of the following exercises that you did.

- ❑ 1. Used words and voice tone to say a thought over and over; as fast as I could; very, very slowly; in a voice different from mine; as a dialogue on a TV comedy show; or as singing.
- ❑ 2. Relaxed my face and body imagining accepting my thoughts as sensations of my brain.
- ❑ 3. Imagined what I would do if I stopped believing everything I think.
- ❑ 4. Rehearsed in my mind what I would do if I did not view my thoughts as facts.
- ❑ 5. Practiced loving my thoughts as they went through my mind.
- ❑ 6. Refocused my mind on sensations I was avoiding by worrying or catastrophizing.
- ❑ 7. Allowed my thoughts to come and go as I focused on observing my breath coming in and out.
- ❑ 8. Labeled the thought as a thought, saying, "The thought [describe thought] arose in my mind."
- ❑ 9. Asked, "Where did the thought come from?" and watched my mind to find out.
- ❑ 10. Stepped back from my mind, as if I was on top of a mountain.
- ❑ 11. Shuttled back and forth between scanning for physical sensations and scanning for thoughts.
- ❑ 12. Imagined that in my mind thoughts were coming down a conveyor belt; were boats on a river; were train cars on a railroad track; were written on leaves flowing down a river; had wings and could fly away; were clouds floating in the sky; or were going in and out of the doors of my mind. (Underline the image you used.)
- ❑ 13. Other:_____

Describe thoughts you were mindful of during the week. State just each thought as it went through your mind.

1. Thought: _____
Describe strategies you used or give numbers from above: _____
Circle how effective was this at helping you be more mindful and less reactive:

1	2	3	4	5
Not effective		*Somewhat effective*		*Very effective*

2. Thought: _____
Describe strategies you used or give numbers from above: _____
Circle how effective was this at helping you be more mindful and less reactive:

1	2	3	4	5
Not effective		*Somewhat effective*		*Very effective*

3. Thought: _____
Describe strategies you used or give numbers from above: _____
Circle how effective was this at helping you be more mindful and less reactive:

1	2	3	4	5
Not effective		*Somewhat effective*		*Very effective*

DISTRESS TOLERANCE WORKSHEET 12A (Distress Tolerance Handouts 15, 15a)

Practicing Mindfulness of Thoughts

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Practice allowing the mind twice each day. Describe what strategy you used to allow your thoughts, and what thoughts you had. (See Distress Tolerance Worksheet 12 for ideas.) Rate your experience below.

What did you do to practice allowing your thoughts?	What were you having trouble accepting (if any)?	How much time passed in doing this skill?	rate before/after skill use			Conclusions or questions about this skills practice
			Acceptance (0 = none at all; 5 = I am at peace with this)	Emotion		
				Negative emotion intensity (0–100)	Positive emotion intensity (0–100)	
Mon			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Tues			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Wed			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Thurs			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Fri			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Sat			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	
Sun			/	/	/	
			/	/	/	

Adapted from an unpublished worksheet by Seth Axelrod, with his permission.

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